

THE CALM PARENT SERIES

Raising Emotionally Intelligent Kids

*How to Teach Feelings Before They
Become Problems*

Disclaimer

This book is intended for educational and informational purposes only. Parenting involves highly individual circumstances, and what works for one child and family may not work for another.

Nothing in this book constitutes medical, psychological, or professional parenting advice. For children with diagnosed developmental, behavioral, or mental health conditions, please consult qualified professionals.

The author and publisher do not claim any specific parenting outcomes from the practices described. Always trust your knowledge of your own child and consult professionals when in doubt.

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Emotion Coaching: The Research

John Gottman's research on emotion coaching produced one of the most actionable findings in parenting science.

The Findings

Gottman's longitudinal research on family emotion dynamics found that children whose parents practiced 'emotion coaching' — recognizing emotional moments as opportunities for connection and teaching — had dramatically better outcomes: higher academic performance, fewer behavioral problems, stronger friendships, and better physical health over time.

Emotion-coached children weren't children who felt only positive emotions. They were children who had learned that all emotions are valid information, that they can be experienced and expressed without catastrophe, and that trusted adults will help them navigate the complex ones.

"Emotion coaching is the highest-ROI parenting practice available."

The Five Steps of Emotion Coaching

Gottman's emotion coaching approach translates directly into specific parent behaviors.

The Steps in Practice

Step 1 — Become aware of your child's emotions: notice what they're feeling, even when they can't say it. Step 2 — Recognize the emotional moment as an opportunity: not a problem to solve or a crisis to contain, but a chance to connect. Step 3 — Listen empathetically: get down to their level, make eye contact, reflect back what you're observing ('It looks like you're feeling really frustrated'). Step 4 — Help your child name the feeling: expand their emotional vocabulary beyond 'sad' and 'mad.' Step 5 — Set limits while problem-solving: all feelings are okay; not all behaviors are. 'It makes sense that you're angry. Hitting is not okay. What else could you do when you feel that angry?'

"The emotion coaching framework works for kids because it works for humans."

Building Emotional Vocabulary

Children can only work with the emotions they can name.

The Vocabulary Investment

Research by Lisa Feldman Barrett shows that the more differentiated our emotional vocabulary, the better we regulate emotions — because we can identify what we're experiencing precisely enough to address it specifically.

Building emotional vocabulary in children: use emotion words in daily conversation beyond 'happy,' 'sad,' 'angry,' and 'scared.' Introduce words like frustrated, disappointed, embarrassed, jealous, proud, anxious, lonely, content, curious. Read books with rich emotional content. Talk about characters' feelings.

The investment pays dividends in adolescence — children with larger emotional vocabularies handle the intensely emotional adolescent period with more nuance and less crisis.

"You can't manage what you can't name."

Validating Feelings Without Validating Every Behavior

The critical distinction: all feelings are okay; all behaviors are not.

The Validation Formula

Validation is not agreement. 'I understand why you're angry' does not mean 'you were right to hit your brother.' These are completely separate statements.

Validation communicates: your feeling makes sense, you are not wrong for having it, I can understand your inner experience. Behavior limits communicate: this specific action is not acceptable and here is what is.

Children who receive validation for their feelings are actually more responsive to behavioral limits — because the validation removes the defensive charge that makes children dig in.

"Validate the feeling. Limit the behavior. Never confuse the two."

When Your Child Won't Talk to You

The goal of emotional attunement in early childhood is to maintain access to your child through adolescence.

The Long Game

Children who have experienced their parents as emotionally available — who have been met with curiosity rather than judgment when they bring difficult feelings — are significantly more likely to continue bringing difficult feelings as adolescents.

The investment in emotion coaching in the early years is, in part, an investment in the relationship quality that will matter most when the stakes are high: when they're navigating peer pressure, relationship decisions, mental health challenges.

The teen who goes to a parent instead of only to peers does so because they have evidence from years of experience that the parent can be a safe emotional landing place.

*"Early emotional attunement is an investment
in adolescent access."*

Helping Kids With Anxiety

Childhood anxiety is common, manageable, and significantly influenced by the parental response to it.

The Parental Response That Helps vs. Hurts

Accommodation — repeatedly removing anxiety-provoking situations to relieve the child's distress — provides short-term relief and long-term anxiety reinforcement. The anxious child needs gradual supported engagement with feared situations, not protection from them.

Helpful responses: acknowledging the anxiety without amplifying it ('I can see this feels scary. You've handled scary things before'), coaching the child through anxiety rather than removing it, expressing confidence in the child's ability to cope ('You can do hard things').

For significant childhood anxiety, CBT-based treatment (specifically, the SPACE program) has strong evidence for both the child and the parent component of treatment.

"Help your child through anxiety, not around it."
